Response to reviewers

QLoRA Fine-Tuning for Consumer Complaint Classification

Thank you for the detailed reviews. We revised the manuscript and completed the corrected-allocation experiments, validation searches, repeated refits, input-length sensitivity and controlled latency analysis. The main text reports the central findings; the supplement contains full searches, seed results, dependence diagnostics and reference-parameter conditions. We distinguish observed points, conditional confidence intervals, seed SD and paired differences throughout. The manuscript and supplement describe the study as a self-contained research report, without narrating changes between manuscript versions. This response letter identifies the changes requested by the reviewers. Configuration-screening fits and auxiliary dependence analyses are distinguished by their data allocations and scientific scope rather than by manuscript chronology.

This is the local author-review version dated 26 October 2026. It has not been submitted. Actual external reviewer/public access still needs to be arranged; unavailable historical upstream preprocessing/checkpoint identities remain disclosed limitations. The response does not treat these gaps as recovered. R1.1–R1.8 and R2.1–R2.7 are our tracking IDs, not numbering supplied by the reviewers. Reviewer #2's combined paragraph is split into its seven actionable sentences; the full original text is preserved in the accompanying coverage file. Location page numbers refer to the separately paginated compiled manuscript and supplementary PDFs.

Reviewer #1

R1.1 — Legacy dependence

> Legacy statistics: The 12 subsets contain only 5,909 unique pairs, so the Wilcoxon test ($p = 2^{-12}$) assumes independence that isn't shown. Provide an overlap matrix and use a group-aware paired analysis.

Response. We agree that the twelve files are not twelve independent experiments and have removed the subset-level Wilcoxon inference. Their 12,000 appearances contain 5,909 unique normalised label–narrative units. We supply both complete 12-by-12 overlap-count matrices, the file key and per-view descriptive scores. The aggregate equally weights unique units rather than repeated appearances. Label-blind full-text/prefix components link dependent units into 3,919 groups. The analysis resamples whole groups, with the same draw for every compared system. These are conservative text-dependency groups, not verified complaint identities. On the corrected-data legacy aggregate, Qwen and Llama macro-F1 adaptation gains are 0.1886 [0.1723, 0.2051] and 0.2000 [0.1838, 0.2166]. The intervals condition on fitted models; the files remain source-related views, not independent-source validation.

Changes and locations. Manuscript Section 3.5 (p. 6); Manuscript Section 4.2 (p. 8); Supplementary material Section S4 (p. 10); Supplementary material Table S17 (p. 11); Supplementary material Table S18 (p. 11); Supplementary material Table S13 (p. 9).

R1.2 — Model-visible overlap and corrected allocation

> Leakage audit: Splits group full narratives, but models see 500-character truncations. Audit overlap after truncation and prompt construction, and narrow the "no leakage" claim.

Response. The additional audit found that full-narrative grouping had not prevented all model-visible collisions: 192 shared unique 500-character training inputs touch 584 internal-test rows in the archived allocation. We therefore do not describe the archived experiments as leakage-free. Label-blind connected components now include normalised full text, 500-character representations, reconstructed tokenizer inputs and a conservative legacy 250-character prefix guard. Giving existing evaluation records priority quarantines 2,925 training and 307 validation rows; no evaluation record is moved into fitting. We repeated the affected model study on the corrected allocation. Each of five actual pinned tokenizers was audited on 39,428 inputs, including the identical 10k/2k selections and all evaluation appearances; audited train/validation-to-evaluation token-identity intersections are empty. Longer-input and separate reference-parameter keys were also checked. Our claim is limited to the representations tested, with no semantic/paraphrase independence guarantee. The previously inspected internal test remains retrospective.

Changes and locations. Manuscript Section 3.2 (p. 4); Manuscript Table 2 (p. 4); Supplementary material Section S1 (p. 2); Supplementary material Table S3 (p. 2); Supplementary material Section S7 (p. 16).

R1.3 — Data provenance and reproducibility access

> Reproducibility: Explain how the 162,415 rows were derived, give the label mapping and subset construction, and release code, manifests and predictions to reviewers.

Response. We reconstructed the local derivation: the source archive contains 162,421 rows, and its first 162,415 records match the working file by index, label and narrative. The six absent trailing records contain only the placeholder narrative "name"; the available evidence does not establish who removed them or when. Ten missing-field records are excluded, then the earlier 8,123 legacy-related exclusions leave the original 154,282-row pool. The revised retained train/validation/internal counts are 120,502/15,120/15,428. We document the inherited five-label identity mapping, class counts, fixed selections and byte-identical legacy files, including their balanced/imbalanced and 250/500-character conditions. The unavailable upstream CFPB-to-Kaggle extraction/product aggregation and original sampling implementation are explicitly disclosed. A local archive contains source/derived data, scripts, manifests and predictions with SHA-256 verification; neural weights are omitted and exact new commits are supplied for reproduction. We added a standalone CPU replay command (Supplementary Section S8): it checks frozen source hashes and recomputes eight complete main/reference result tables, including paired intervals, seed scores, length effects and latency, without model weights or historical original-paper files. New outputs are isolated from archived evidence. This improves local reproducibility, but does not complete the request for access by reviewers: no external access mechanism or public release has been arranged. The author must arrange actual access under journal requirements before submission.

Changes and locations. Manuscript Section 3.1 (p. 3); Manuscript Section 3.2 (p. 4); Manuscript Section 6 (p. 10); Supplementary material Section S1 (p. 2); Supplementary material Table S16 (p. 11); Supplementary material Section S8 (p. 17).

R1.4 — Implementation and immutable model identities

> Implementation details: State the Qwen3 thinking setting, checkpoint IDs, full QLoRA configuration and library versions.

Response. The revised Methods state Qwen enable_thinking=False, single chat-template rendering without duplicate BOS, greedy decoding, one beam and a maximum of 32 new tokens. JSON prompting is followed by final-product-field regex parsing, with invalid/absent labels counted as errors and no retries. The new QLoRA runs use 4-bit NF4, double quantisation, FP16 compute, rank 16, alpha 32, dropout 0.05, all-linear targets and completion-only JSON/EOS loss. They use two epochs, learning rate 0.0002, physical batch 1/accumulation 16, paged AdamW 8-bit, cosine scheduling, warmup 0.03, non-reentrant checkpointing and validation-loss checkpoint selection. The supplement includes the exact prompt, full 40-character model commits and actual library/hardware versions; per-run files retain code, environment and weight hashes. Exact-input memoisation is disclosed for deterministic prediction generation only; latency and warmups make fresh calls. These completed new pins/configurations do not recover missing historical upstream commits or final historical Qwen artifacts.

Changes and locations. Manuscript Section 3.3 (p. 5); Supplementary material Table S4 (p. 3); Supplementary material Table S5 (p. 3); Supplementary material Table S6 (p. 4); Supplementary material Section S8 (p. 17).

R1.5 — Matched baselines, searches and separate reference sensitivity

> Baselines: Tune the encoders and TF-IDF comparably (three seeds, validation search), and compare in one table with uncertainty. Margins over TF-IDF are small.

Response. All revised families share the same 10,000 training and 2,000 validation records. TF-IDF/LR has a 48-candidate validation search at each of the 10k and full-data budgets. BERT, DistilBERT and RoBERTa each have six validation candidates (three learning rates by two epoch counts), followed by fresh refits with optimisation seeds 42/43/44. All candidates and selected configurations are supplied. Sparse lbfgs refits are deterministic checks, not stochastic seed evidence. One main table now reports corrected-data accuracy, macro-F1, weighted F1, macro-F1 interval and separate seed SD. Qwen/Llama adapted macro-F1 is 0.8331/0.8402 versus 0.8068 for 10k TF-IDF; paired differences are 0.0263 [0.0199, 0.0327] and 0.0334 [0.0270, 0.0397]. Full-data TF-IDF reaches 0.8476 with 120,502 training rows and is explicitly unequal-budget context. Encoder-versus-10k-TF-IDF macro-F1 intervals include zero. We additionally report six refits using the encoder caps/physical batch in Ref. [14] Tables III–IV: BERT 128 tokens and RoBERTa 100 tokens, batch 16/accumulation 1. The main encoders remain at the inherited 500 narrative characters with a 512-token ceiling, batch 4/accumulation 4. Ref. [14] conditions are separate sensitivity runs, not a new universal RoBERTa limit or an exact replication. Internal macro-F1 differences from main are -0.0017 (BERT) and -0.0010 (RoBERTa), with paired intervals including zero; no main baseline was replaced using test results.

Changes and locations. Manuscript Section 3.4 (p. 5); Manuscript Table 3 (p. 7); Manuscript Table 4 (p. 7); Supplementary material Table S7 (p. 4); Supplementary material Table S8 (p. 5); Supplementary material Section S7 (p. 16); Supplementary material Table S28 (p. 16).

R1.6 — Paired bootstrap, point estimates and seed variation

> Bootstrap: Use a paired, group-level bootstrap with more replicates, report seed variation separately, and reconcile Tables 2 and 3.

Response. The revised analysis uses 10,000 paired whole-group bootstrap draws (seed 20261020), with shared group multiplicities across compared variants. Internal estimates score all 15,428 rows in 12,099 dependency groups. Legacy estimates use the unique-unit weighting described above. Points are computed on the observed data before resampling; means over three refits are means of separately scored models, not ensembles. Across-refit sample SD is reported separately from the conditional bootstrap interval. The interval does not include training or hyperparameter-selection uncertainty; selection/memberships are fixed and no multiplicity adjustment is claimed. The supplement explains the computationally equivalent multinomial compression of identical joint group-confusion profiles. The separate reference analysis uses its own common draws and compression, so the same random seed does not imply identical Monte Carlo draws between analyses. Historical Tables 2/3 are reconciled with the same observed estimator in explicitly historical-only supplementary tables. Original and corrected-training results are not mixed into one ranking. The supplement now also gives the explicit confusion-count, seed-average and paired resampling equations; the CPU replay checks all reported estimates against saved predictions.

Changes and locations. Manuscript Section 3.5 (p. 6); Manuscript Table 3 (p. 7); Manuscript Table 4 (p. 7); Supplementary material Section S3 (p. 6); Supplementary material Table S11 (p. 8); Supplementary material Table S32 (p. 18); Supplementary material Table S33 (p. 18).

R1.7 — Contribution and related work

> Contribution and claims: Compare explicitly with [14] and [15], and remove or test claims about reuse, "external" benchmark and robustness.

Response. We expanded the comparison with Güllü et al. [14], explicitly acknowledging their financial five-category task and Llama-3.1 fine-tuning. The difference is our within-model zero-shot-to-explicit-NF4-QLoRA question for two 8B families, fixed labelled-data budget, actual refits and dependence-aware corrected evaluation—not first use of LLMs, a new taxonomy or a new PEFT algorithm. Missing descriptions in [14] are described as reporting differences, not proof of absent procedures. Their weighted scores and different split/budget are not ranked against our macro-F1. Roumeliotis et al. [15] is distinguished as zero-shot evaluation; its exclusion of narratives over 500 characters differs from our inherited truncation convention. "External benchmark" is replaced by source-related legacy views. Untested taxonomy reuse, independent-source generalisation and broad robustness claims have been removed. The discussion centres on measured adaptation gains, baseline competitiveness and costs.

Changes and locations. Manuscript Table 1 (p. 3); Manuscript Section 3.1 (p. 3); Manuscript Section 5 (p. 10); Manuscript Section 6 (p. 10); Supplementary material Section S7 (p. 16).

R1.8 — Truncation and controlled latency

> Truncation and deployment: Report results by truncation and add a longer-context experiment. Control the latency measurements and avoid claiming acceptability or regulatory readiness.

Response. The 500-character narrative cap is inherited from the original protocol; 512 is its tokenizer ceiling. We do not claim that 500 characters is optimal, harmless or necessary for this GPU. Only 63.98% of usable source narratives fit that cap. We report historical length strata and matched changed-input views separately, and completed the same-checkpoint inference comparison at 500/512, 500/2048 and 1,500/2048 character/token settings. The latter is a reviewer-requested inference sensitivity, not a new main training cutoff. The 500-character token-cap control produces identical predictions with no extra clipping. At 1,500 versus 500 characters (both 2,048-token ceilings), adapted Qwen/Llama macro-F1 improves by 0.0072 [0.0048, 0.0097] and 0.0055 [0.0029, 0.0081]. In the predefined >500-character cohort (5,770 rows/5,131 groups), gains are 0.0156 [0.0105, 0.0209] and 0.0117 [0.0065, 0.0172]. Zero-shot Qwen instead decreases by 0.0072; zero-shot Llama's interval includes zero. Thus more text does not uniformly help. Controlled batch-one latency uses 100 preselected internal IDs, 20/class, ten validation warmups and three timed repetitions in each of 24 conditions (7,200 measured calls). At the main input setting, paired adapted-minus-base end-to-end mean increases are 0.1224 s [0.1166, 0.1284] for Qwen and 0.0802 s [0.0758, 0.0847] for Llama. We report generation/end-to-end means, medians, p95 and token counts. Output lengths vary; separate job blocks are not a fully randomised crossover or thermal-equivalence test. Batch-one serial timing does not establish concurrent-service capacity, acceptability or regulatory readiness, and those claims are removed.

Changes and locations. Manuscript Section 3.6 (p. 6); Manuscript Table 5 (p. 9); Manuscript Table 6 (p. 10); Manuscript Section 6 (p. 10); Supplementary material Section S5 (p. 12); Supplementary material Table S23 (p. 13); Supplementary material Table S24 (p. 14); Supplementary material Section S6 (p. 14); Supplementary material Table S26 (p. 15).

Reviewer #2

R2.1 — Positioning against Ref. [14]

> The authors should strengthen the positioning against closely related recent studies, especially Reference [14], and clarify the distinction between the proposed approach and prior LLM-based complaint classification methods.

Response. We agree and revised the Introduction/Related work and a dedicated protocol-comparison table. Güllü et al. already fine-tune LLMs for the same financial label taxonomy. Our contribution is the explicit, budget-conditional paired adaptation protocol and its evidence, not the first application or a cross-paper score improvement. The report distinguishes the supervised comparison in [14] from zero-shot work in [15]. We also include the separate source-parameter encoder sensitivity without relabelling it as exact replication. See response R1.7 and R1.5 for the measured results.

Changes and locations. Manuscript Table 1 (p. 3); Manuscript Section 5 (p. 10); Supplementary material Section S7 (p. 16).

R2.2 — Same-source benchmark terminology

> The term "external benchmark" should be reconsidered because the benchmark originates from the same CFPB data source.

Response. We replaced the external-benchmark claim with source-related legacy evaluation views. The twelve preserved files originate from the related CFPB resource, overlap extensively and are not twelve independent replications. We now quantify their overlap, equally weight unique visible units and use conservative group-aware inference. No independent-source generalisation follows.

Changes and locations. Manuscript Section 3.1 (p. 3); Manuscript Section 3.5 (p. 6); Supplementary material Section S4 (p. 10).

R2.3 — Configuration, truncation and training budget

> The manuscript would also benefit from a more complete description of the QLoRA and inference configurations and clearer justification of the 500-character truncation and 10,000-example training budget.

Response. The new implementation is specified with immutable commits, complete QLoRA settings, exact prompt, thinking disabled, greedy generation and strict output parsing. See R1.4 for the full settings. The inherited 500-character narrative cap and separate 512-token ceiling keep the main paired input convention fixed; we make no optimality or hardware-necessity claim. The longer-input experiment reports benefits and failures rather than assuming the cap harmless. The common 10k/2k selection is a fixed labelled-data comparison budget inherited from the original study, not a demonstrated sample-efficiency optimum. All revised families share it; full-data TF-IDF is separate unequal-budget context. The 100-token RoBERTa setting appears only in the Ref. [14] Table IV supplementary sensitivity, while main RoBERTa uses 512 tokens. To make the configuration provenance explicit, we restored the six earlier Qwen validation conditions and their natural/balanced sampling comparison in Supplementary Section S8. These pre-quarantine scores explain the transferred settings; they are kept separate from the corrected-data validation searches and final comparisons.

Changes and locations. Manuscript Section 3.3 (p. 5); Manuscript Section 3.4 (p. 5); Manuscript Table 5 (p. 9); Supplementary material Section S2 (p. 3); Supplementary material Section S7 (p. 16); Supplementary material Table S34 (p. 19).

R2.4 — Statistical methodology

> The statistical evaluation and bootstrap methodology should be described more clearly.

Response. We now define the observed-point estimator, legacy weights, conservative dependency components, 10,000 shared paired group-bootstrap draws and conditional scope. Seed sample SD is separate from the bootstrap interval; refit metrics are averaged, not prediction ensembles. Selection/training uncertainty and multiplicity are not covered. The complete seed/metric/contrast tables and historical point/interval reconciliation are supplied; see R1.6.

Changes and locations. Manuscript Section 3.5 (p. 6); Supplementary material Section S3 (p. 6); Supplementary material Table S11 (p. 8); Supplementary material Table S33 (p. 18).

R2.5 — Constrained decoding, robustness and deployment

> Claims concerning constrained decoding, robustness, and deployment should also be moderated where appropriate.

Response. The text now accurately describes JSON prompting followed by regex extraction, not token-level constrained decoding. Invalid labels count as errors; observed compliance is not a guarantee. We removed untested reuse/general robustness and deployment-readiness claims. Completed same-checkpoint input sensitivity and controlled fresh-call latency quantify specific effects, with negative/uncertain results retained. They do not establish independent-source generalisation, production capacity, user acceptability or regulatory readiness; see R1.8.

Changes and locations. Manuscript Section 3.3 (p. 5); Manuscript Section 4.3 (p. 8); Manuscript Section 4.4 (p. 8); Manuscript Section 6 (p. 10); Supplementary material Table S15 (p. 10); Supplementary material Section S6 (p. 14).

R2.6 — Practical PEFT contribution and TF-IDF competitiveness

> Most importantly, the results show that QLoRA achieves performance very close to the TF-IDF + Logistic Regression baseline; therefore, the practical contribution should be framed around the benefits and trade-offs of LLM-based PEFT rather than implying clear classification superiority.

Response. We reframed the abstract, discussion and conclusion around the measured benefits and costs of same-model adaptation. At the common 10k budget, Qwen/Llama QLoRA macro-F1 is 0.8331/0.8402 versus sparse 0.8068, with paired deltas reported rather than universal superiority. Full-data sparse classification reaches 0.8476 with 120,502 training examples; its larger budget is explicit. Qwen is below that full-data comparator by 0.0145 with an interval excluding zero; Llama's -0.0074 interval includes zero (unrounded upper bound +0.0000068). Tuned encoders remain competitive and their contrasts with 10k sparse include zero. We therefore present adaptation gains and inference costs as conditional findings; simpler supervised classifiers remain important practical alternatives.

Changes and locations. Manuscript Table 3 (p. 7); Manuscript Table 4 (p. 7); Manuscript Table 6 (p. 10); Manuscript Section 5 (p. 10); Manuscript Section 7 (p. 11).

R2.7 — Code/configuration access

> Finally, improving public access to the code and experimental configurations would substantially improve reproducibility.

Response. We prepared a local hash-verified reproducibility archive with source/derived data, fixed memberships, scripts, search records, configurations, predictions, analyses and the three document sources/PDFs. Its README now gives an executable CPU replay command and a recorded dependency file. The replay verifies source hashes and compares all cells and row identities of eight recomputed result tables with the archived results, without a GPU, neural weights, local model registry or the protected original-paper directory. Repeating neural fitting separately requires the pinned model snapshots and a fresh project checkout, as documented; no unsupported generic output-directory option is implied. It omits neural weights and third-party papers, records exact new model commits and distinguishes unrecovered historical provenance. However, local preparation does not establish public or reviewer access. No upload or message has been sent, and no external access mechanism is claimed. Arranging actual reviewer/public

access and checking the journal's anonymity requirements remain author submission tasks. We have kept this part of the request explicitly open rather than claiming it is completed.

Changes and locations. Supplementary material Section S8 (p. 17); Supplementary material Table S30 (p. 18); Manuscript Section 6 (p. 10).